Midterm Information Study

Participant setup & study explainer

Thank you very much for taking part in this study. This guide shows you how to install the study extension, what to expect during the study, and how to control recording.

Important Information at a glance

Daily study window	12:00 pm noon until 12:00 am midnight (your local time)
Check-ins	Daily between 5:00 pm–09:00 pm.
Browser	Please keep Chrome open and do most of your browsing in Chrome during the study period. When you are currently not browsing, you can just minimize Chrome.

Most important

During the study window, **leave Chrome open whenever possible and use Chrome for most of your normal browsing**. The extension can only work with Chrome, and Chrome needs to be open to deliver study reminders.

Quick daily checklist

☐ Chrome is open during 12:00 pm –12:00 am whenever practical.

☐ I do most of my browsing in Chrome during the study window.

☐ I open the side panel when I receive a study check-in.

☐ I use “I’m finished” when I am done with a prompted information-search episode.

☐ If I pause recording, I remember that it will automatically start recording again on the next study day.

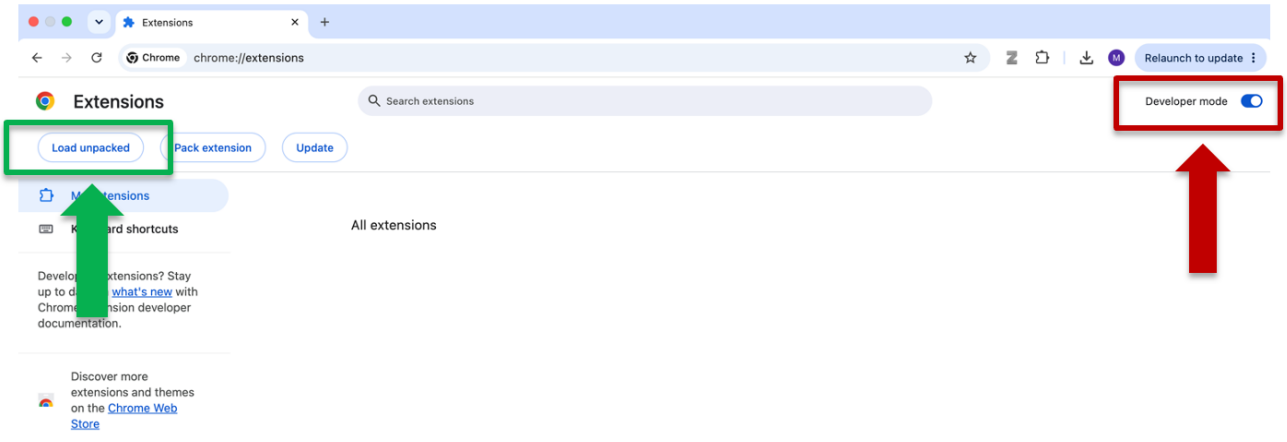
You are ready

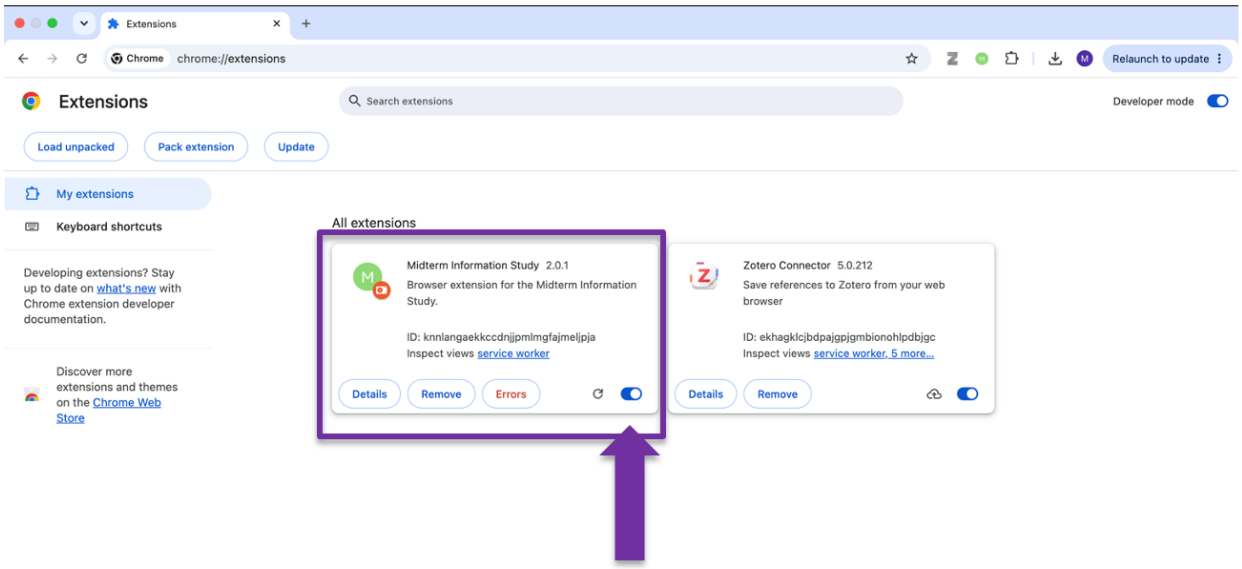
Once the extension is installed, pinned, enrolled, and able to show a test notification, you are ready for the study.

1. Install the study extension

For this study, the extension is provided as a folder you receive after clicking the link at the end of the survey. You only need to download it once.

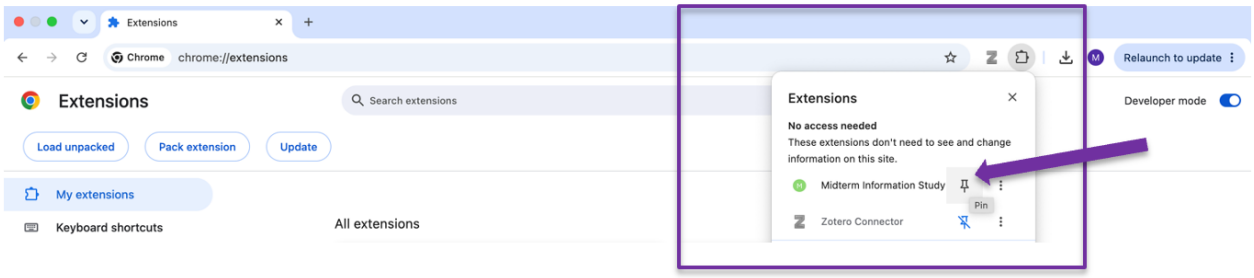
1. **Download the study folder.** Save it somewhere you can easily find again.
2. **Open Chrome and go to chrome://extensions.** You can type this directly into the address bar in Chrome
3. **Turn on Developer mode** (usually in the upper-right corner, see marked in red below)
4. **Click "Load unpacked"** (usually in the top left corner, marked in green below). Choose the folder.
5. **Keep the folder on your computer until the study ends.** Do not move it to another location on your computer or delete it while the extension is installed.
6. **Once the extension appears, make sure you turn on the switch** (see marked in purple below)





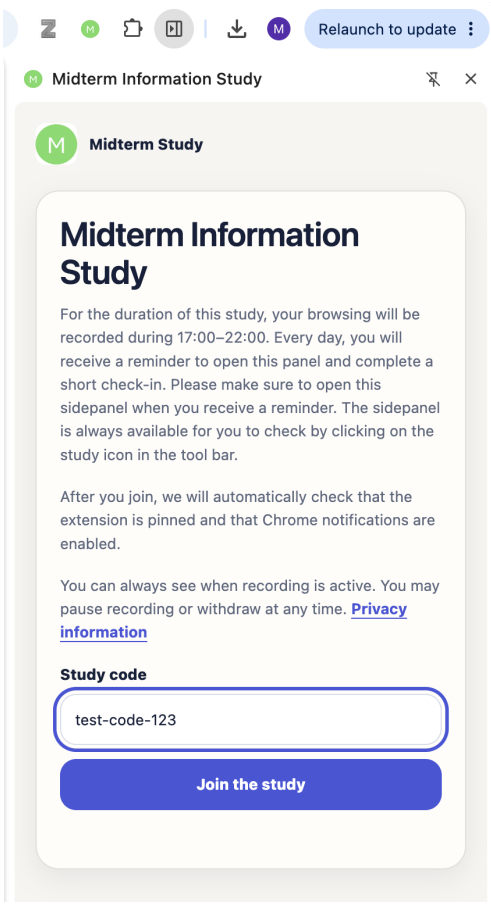
Pin the extension

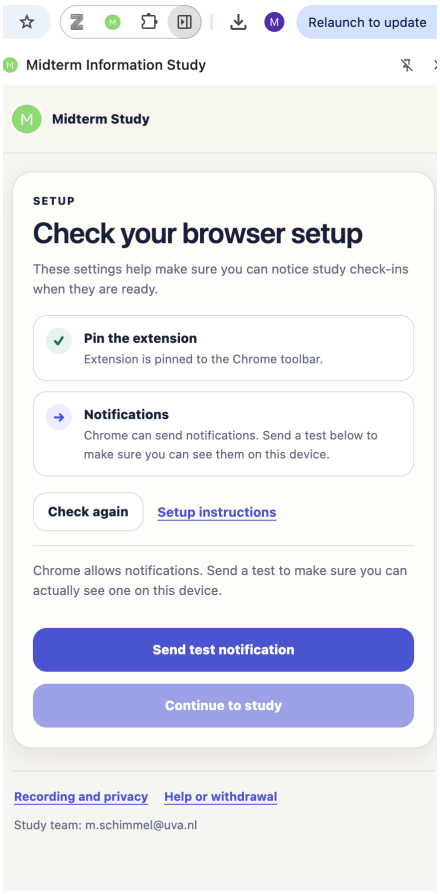
Click Chrome's Extensions (puzzle-piece) icon and pin the Midterm Information Study. The study icon should then stay visible in your toolbar. Click that icon whenever you want to open the study side panel.



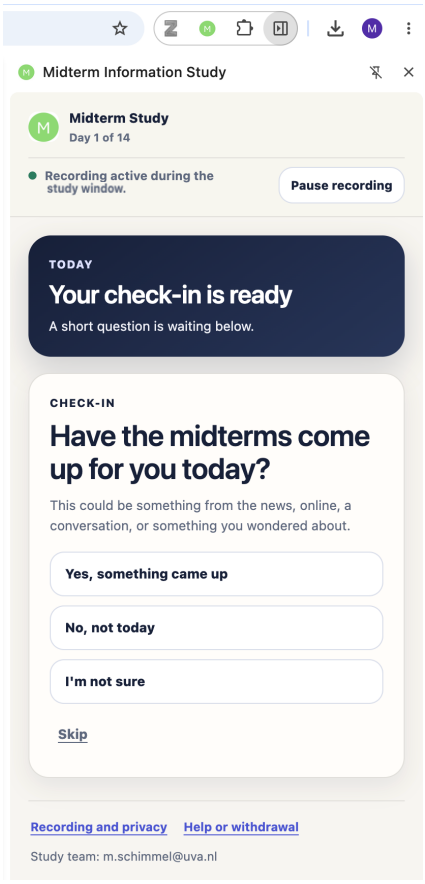
2. Finish setup before the study starts

7. **Open the study side panel by clicking the pinned study icon in the Chrome toolbar.**
8. **Enter your study code.** Type the code you received from the research team and click "Join the study"
9. **Test notifications.** Use the study's "send test notification" button, and watch for a notification to appear. If nothing appears, allow Chrome notifications in your system settings and try again.





10. **Check the side panel home screen.** After joining, you should see the Midterm Study panel and its recording status. If you can see it, you're all set!



3. What to do during the study

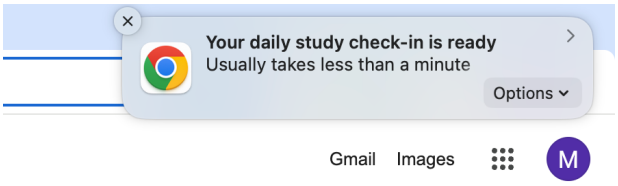
Keep Chrome available

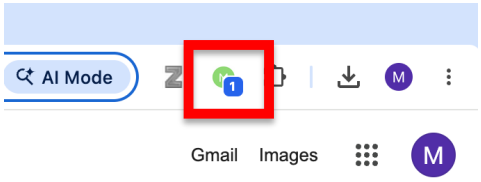
Between 12 pm and 12 am, please keep Chrome open whenever possible and do most of your normal browsing in Chrome. You do not need to keep the study side panel open all the time.

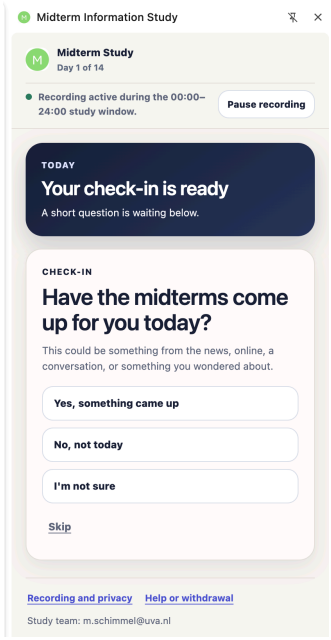
For the duration of this study, you will receive regular study reminders to complete a short question and task. Between 12 pm and 12 am, your browsing activity in Chrome will be recorded. Sensitive domains are not recording by default (you can check section 6 for more details about what is recorded). If you want to pause browser recording, you can always do so via the pause button in the study side panel.

Daily Check-ins

You will receive daily check-in notifications telling you that your study check-in is ready. **If you do not receive these notifications, make sure to adjust your settings, or check the study panel after 5 pm yourself.** If you have set up study reminders and do not open the extension will show additional reminders. Open the side panel from the notification or by clicking the pinned study icon. Your home screen will display that your check-in is ready



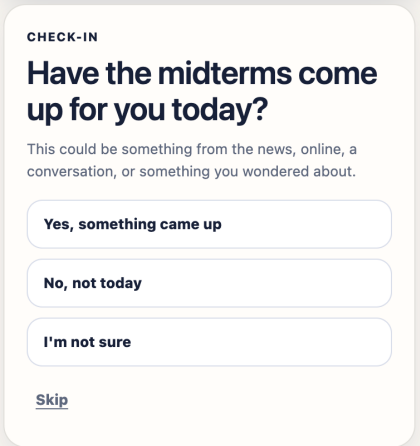




4. Check-in: step by step

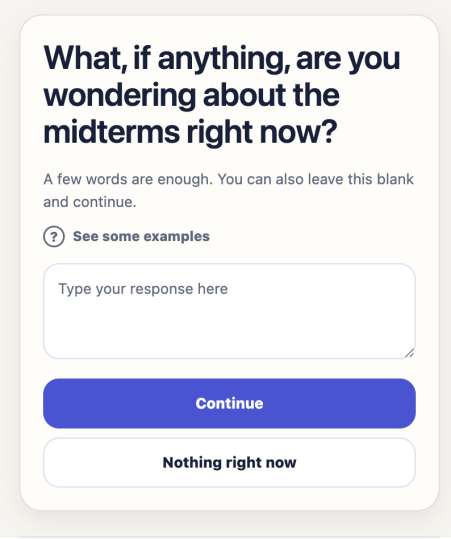
Step 1: Tell us whether the midterms came up for you

The first question asks: “Have the midterms come up for you today?” This can include something you saw in the news or online, a conversation, or something you wondered about. Choose the answer that fits best. You can also skip the check-in.



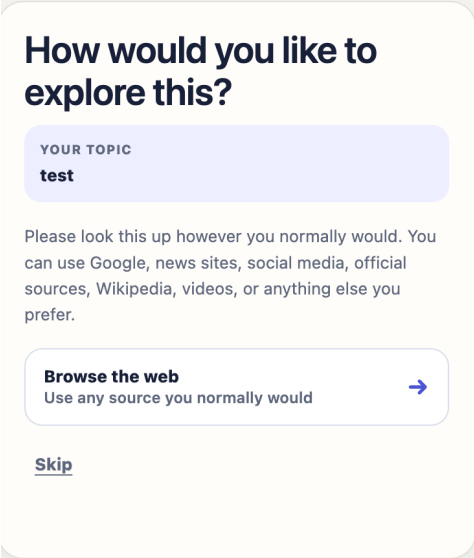
Step 2: Add a topic if you want to look something up

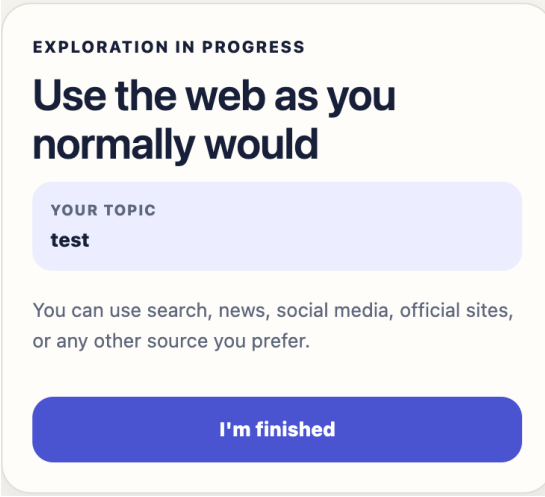
Whether or not something came up about the midterms that day, you will be asked if there is currently something you are wondering about the midterms that you would like to look up. A few words are enough, and you can leave the box blank. You can also click on the question mark icon to see some example questions. Choose “Nothing right now” if you do not want to start an information-search episode.



Step 3: Explore the topic how you normally would

Use the web as you normally would. A new tab is automatically opened, and you can use search engines, news sites, official websites, social media, or any other sources you wish. When you are finished, return to the side panel and click “I’m finished”.





If the episode is still open after about 15 minutes, the panel may ask “Still looking?”. Choose “Continue looking” if you are not finished yet, or “I’m done” to end the episode and move to the short follow-up.

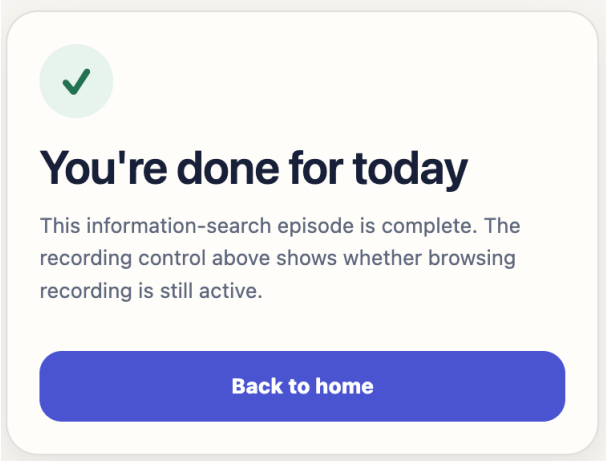
Step 5: Post-episode questions

On some days, you receive a few short questions after an information searching episode.



Step 6: Episode complete

When the prompted episode is complete, the side panel confirms that you are done with that episode. This does not necessarily mean browsing recording has stopped: recording normally continues until the end of the daily study window unless you pause it. You can always see if recording is active.

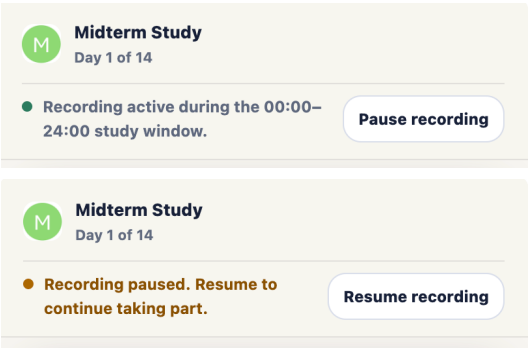


5. Recording, privacy, and pausing

When browsing recording is active

Browsing recording is designed to operate only during the daily study window and study dates. The side panel shows whether recording is active, paused, or off. When recording is paused, it is automatically resumed once a new study time window begins the next day and can be paused again manually if necessary.

- If you answer a pending check-in and continue with the prompted flow, browsing recording is automatically resumed.



What the study records

During the study window, the extension records information needed to understand how people seek and encounter information online. This includes:

- **Web browsing activity:** the sites/pages visited in Chrome and when they were visited, including page timing information and HTML captures.
- **Search activity:** search queries, search-result pages, AI Overviews shown on supported search pages, and links clicked from search results.
- **News exposure on supported news sites:** headlines shown, headline clicks, and information from opened articles used to measure what content was encountered and read.
- **Social media exposure on supported networks:** Note that personal messages (DMs) are left out of the study recording by default and all usernames will be anonymised.
- **Study interactions:** check-in answers, optional text you enter into the study panel, and the short post-episode follow-up.
- **Basic technical information:** timestamps and limited browser/extension/device information used to check whether the extension is working.
- **The extension applies privacy filters and redaction rules for sensitive destinations** and selected account/settings pages. The participant privacy information linked in the side panel is the authoritative description of study data handling.

Outside the study window

Outside 12 pm– 12am, the study's browsing recording is off. An already-started prompted flow may have its own completion behavior, so use the "I'm finished" control when you are done.

7. Withdrawing or getting help

Participation is voluntary. You can pause browsing recording at any time, and you can withdraw from the study if you no longer want to take part.

To withdraw

Email the study team at m.schimmel@uva.nl. Please write “Midterm Information Study Withdrawal” in the subject line.

If you want the extension to stop immediately, remove or disable it in Chrome. Go to chrome://extensions, find Midterm Information Study, and choose Remove or switch it off.

For questions about data already collected, contact the study team. The consent and privacy information govern how withdrawal and any data-deletion request are handled.

> **Important**
> Simply closing Chrome or pausing recording does not register a formal withdrawal. Please contact the study team if you want to withdraw from the study.

Need help?

- If the side panel does not open, click the pinned study icon in the Chrome toolbar.
- If notifications do not appear, check that Chrome is allowed to send notifications in your computer’s system settings.
- If the extension is disabled, open chrome://extensions and switch Midterm Information Study back on.
- For any other problem, contact m.schimmel@uva.nl.